

THE KINGDOM BEYOND THE MIST

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CHAPTER ONE

The Border

The kingdom had feared the mist for four hundred years.

Children were taught never to approach it.

Soldiers were forbidden from entering it.

Even kings avoided speaking its name.

Elara had grown up hearing stories about what lived beyond the silver wall of fog.

Monsters.

Lost kingdoms.

Dead kings.

People who entered and returned without aging.

She had never believed any of them.

Until her brother disappeared.

Prince Kael had vanished four days earlier.

No guards.

No horses.

No footprints.

Nothing.

The king had ordered the entire northern forest searched.

Nothing was found.

Elara knew what her father refused to admit.

Kael had gone toward the mist.

She stood at the forest boundary before sunrise.

Her horse waited behind her.

She looked back toward the castle.

Then toward the mist.

"I'll bring you home," she whispered.

The mist moved.

A voice came from inside.

"Elara."

She froze.

She knew that voice.

"Kael?"

Something moved between the trees.

A boy stepped forward.

Elara's sword came free.

The boy looked twelve years old.

Kael had been twenty-one.

But the face was unmistakable.

Her brother.

"You shouldn't be here," he said.

Elara's hands trembled.

"What happened to you?"

Kael looked over his shoulder.

"They know you're coming."

"Who?"

The mist behind him began to glow.

Kael grabbed her arm.

"Run."

The forest erupted with sound.

Something enormous moved beneath the fog.

Elara ran.

Not away from the mist.

Into it.

Because her brother was already disappearing inside.